

The Chihuahuan Desert

One of North America's largest deserts and the most species-rich in the Western Hemisphere



Bisected by the Rio Grande, the Chihuahuan Desert is bordered to the west and east by the Sierra Madre Occidental and Oriental (see p.37). It is a rain-shadow desert, formed because the mountains block the flow of moisture-laden air from coastal waters.

High life

Most of the desert lies at an altitude of about 4,500 ft (1,370 m), making the summers slightly milder than in other deserts, although daytime temperatures still exceed 100°F (38°C). The nights can be cold, with snow at higher elevations. Despite such extremes, more than 3,500 plant species flourish here, including more cacti species than in any other desert. While higher slopes are characterized by thick-leaved, frost-hardy yuccas, shrubs such as mesquite and creosote bush dominate the lower region. Such varied habitats support a wide range of wildlife, including bats, roadrunners, and tarantulas. A surprising number of fish are able to survive in pools and oases.

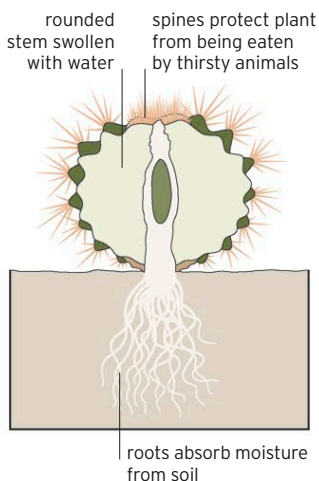


△ WORLD'S LARGEST GYPSUM DUNEFIELD

White gypsum deposits punctuate the Chihuahuan Desert, with the largest concentration in northern New Mexico's Tularosa Basin. Its 275 square miles (712 square km) include the White Sands National Monument.

STORING WATER

Cacti such as the golden barrel are adept at surviving on a limited water supply. The plant's pleated "barrel" is actually a fleshy stem that stores water, expanding and contracting as the supply waxes and wanes. Instead of having leaves that lose moisture through transpiration, it is covered in thorns.



◁ SPIKY MEAL

The Chihuahuan Desert contains over one-fifth of the world's estimated 1,500 cacti species, including this prickly pear. Many animals, such as desert tortoises, eat its pads and fruit—barbs and all.

